

MozFest 2026 — Session Proposal

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TRACK: Founders Wilding

Secondary fit: Wilding Systems

SESSION TITLE:

Rewilding the Startup Ecosystem: Community Ownership, Contribution Economy, and the End of Burnout Culture

SESSION FORMAT: Discussion / Workshop (60–75 minutes)

WHAT IS THIS SESSION ABOUT?

Startup ecosystems have a structural problem that nobody is solving. The people who build them — the mentors, community organizers, event programmers, advisors, researchers, and connectors — do it for free. They burn out. Their organizations collapse. And the ecosystem regresses.

This session introduces Startup Ecosystem 3.0 — a framework for reimagining startup ecosystem infrastructure as community-owned, contribution-rewarded, and financially self-sustaining, without depending on governments, corporations, or philanthropists for survival.

The funding mechanism works as follows. Every verified contribution to a startup ecosystem — a mentoring session, an event organized, a connection made, a resource published, a founder supported — is logged, peer-verified, and rewarded with a utility token native to the SE 3.0 system. This token is not mined, not speculative, and not pre-allocated to investors. It is earned exclusively through documented ecosystem work. The token has two functions: it represents reputation and standing within the ecosystem, and it can be redeemed within the SE 3.0 platform economy for services, resources, and eventually converted into real compensation as the platform generates revenue. The national ecosystem foundation — structured as a nonprofit parent owning a commercial operating entity, a model proven by organizations including the Mozilla Foundation — generates sustainable income through platform services, which flows back into the token economy. For the first time, the people who do the invisible work of building startup communities would be compensated for doing it.

Combined with a decentralized verified trust and reputation layer, an idea proof-of-origin registry, and an AI intelligence layer that makes the entire stack accessible across language barriers — SE 3.0 is an attempt to build the open infrastructure the global startup ecosystem was never given.

This session is not a product pitch. SE 3.0 is an early-stage concept in active development. This session is an invitation to stress-test it, challenge it, and build on it — with exactly the kind of people in this room.

WHY DOES THIS BELONG AT MOZFEST 2026 UNDER THE WILDING THEME?

The Wilding theme asks what happens when we loosen rigid, centralized systems and let communities evolve collectively and naturally. SE 3.0 is a direct application of that question to startup ecosystems — one of the most important but most under-structured communities in the world.

Current startup ecosystems are structured like walled gardens: national silos with no shared infrastructure, controlled by whoever holds the institutional funding, invisible to each other across language barriers, and dependent on outside money that comes with misaligned incentives. That is the opposite of Wilding.

SE 3.0 asks: what if startup ecosystem infrastructure were open, federated, community-governed, and contribution-rewarded? What if a mentor in Zagreb and a community organizer in Nairobi could both be compensated for the same type of verified work through the same system? What if a founder in Tallinn could discover a parallel builder in Seoul before either of them launches — because a language-agnostic idea registry connected them?

That is Wilding applied to economic infrastructure.

The organizational model SE 3.0 proposes for national ecosystem foundations draws on proven structures — including the Mozilla Foundation itself — where a nonprofit parent owns a commercial entity, preserving mission integrity while enabling financial sustainability.

WHO IS THIS FOR?

- Ecosystem builders and community organizers who have done the work without compensation and want to change that
- Founders who have navigated broken or predatory ecosystem support structures and want to design something better
- Technologists and developers interested in real-world utility token design that is not speculative
- Researchers and policy people thinking about the governance of decentralized communities
- Anyone who has ever wondered why startup ecosystems in smaller countries never reach escape velocity — and what the structural fix looks like

WHAT WILL PARTICIPANTS DO?

The session runs in three parts:

Part 1 — The Problem (15 min): A candid, first-person account of what broken startup ecosystem infrastructure looks like from the inside — using the Croatian SE as a documented case study spanning 2009 to 2026. Not a complaint session. A structural diagnosis.

Part 2 — The SE 3.0 Framework (20 min): An overview of the SE 3.0 architecture: the contribution economy, the token mechanics, the trust and reputation layer, the idea registry, and the AI interface. Presented as a concept in development, with deliberate open questions. Participants receive the v0.5 concept document.

Part 3 — Collaborative Stress Test (25–35 min): Participants break into three working groups, each attacking a different open question:

- Group A: How do you prevent the contribution economy from being gamed?
- Group B: What does governance of a global, community-owned ecosystem organization look like?

— Group C: What are the real barriers to adoption in your local ecosystem, and how does SE 3.0 address or fail to address them?

Groups report back. Insights are captured live and fed into the next version of the concept document — with participants credited as contributors.

WHAT WILL PARTICIPANTS LEAVE WITH?

A concrete understanding of a new model for funding and governing startup ecosystem infrastructure. Access to the SE 3.0 concept documents (open, not proprietary). An invitation to continue contributing to the design. And — for those who are also ecosystem builders — the beginning of a network of people working on the same problem across different countries.

ABOUT THE FACILITATOR

Augustin Jarak is a Startup Generalist and Startup Ecosystems Expert. He is a global startup ecosystem researcher and the developer of the SE 3.0 framework. Since 2009, he has studied startup ecosystems across geographies — their structures, failure modes, funding models, and the invisible infrastructure that determines whether they survive or collapse. He coined the term "Startup Generalist" and has spent over a decade building the taxonomy, definitions, and conceptual frameworks that underpin SE 3.0.

His ground-level laboratory has been the Croatian startup ecosystem — one of the most instructive cases precisely because it operates under the constraints that most of the world's ecosystems actually face: limited institutional funding, small market size, geographic and language barriers, and dependence on outside capital with misaligned incentives. He built within it, founded organizations inside it, watched those organizations collapse, and documented why.

He has held active roles in globally networked ecosystem organizations — Chapter Director of Startup Grind Zagreb, Techstars Community Leader for Croatia, Startup Digest Curator for Croatia, Startup Genome Curator for Croatia, Semester President of the Founder Institute Zagreb — not as local outposts, but as nodes in global networks that gave him direct comparative access to how ecosystems function and fail across different countries and contexts.

SE 3.0 is the framework that emerged from that research. Croatia was where it was tested. The world is where it is designed to work.

WHY THIS, WHY NOW?

The SE 3.0 concept documents were first written in May 2026 — weeks before this proposal. The timing is intentional. MozFest is the right first public venue for this idea: technically literate, values-aligned, globally diverse, and built around exactly the kind of participatory session that can improve a framework rather than simply applaud one.

This is not a polished product. It is a serious idea at the stage where serious people in a room can make it significantly better. That is what MozFest is for.